

Story Pesach 5785

This was a shtickle from the Torah Anytimes Haggadah Companion for 5785, and I've shown it to a number of people. Each and every person I've shown it to has been inspired by it to such a degree that I'm willing to read it here to you and hopefully inspire more people, whoever has not yet had the opportunity to see it. It's written by Rabbi Jeremy Golker:

“At the heart of the Seder night lies a profound mission, one that speaks not merely to memory, but to transmission. Rabbi Hool, רב"ל, a pioneering רב in the London Jewish community, would often illustrate this idea with a משל from the jungle.

Once, in the animal kingdom, a unique competition was announced: which creature could project its voice the farthest? Judges were stationed at regular intervals every 200 meters, extending for many kilometers, prepared to measure the range of each contestant's call.

The first to approach the podium was the monkey. With great energy, it let out a wild, piercing scream, which echoed as far as one kilometer. A strong start.

Next came the elephant. Planting itself firmly, it bellowed a deep, thunderous call. Word came back from the markers: it had carried two kilometers. Even better.

Then, with regal confidence, the lion - the king of the jungle - stepped forward. It released a mighty roar that reverberated throughout the forest. After some time, the officials returned with the final tally: eight kilometers. A remarkable feat.

Everyone assumed the lion had claimed the title. But then, quietly and unassuming, a small dove stepped onto the podium. The judges chuckled. “You believe you can surpass the lion?” they asked. “Try me,” replied the dove.

The little bird chirped a soft, barely audible sound that traveled 200 meters. But then a second dove heard it and chirped the same note. That chirp was heard by another bird, and then another, and another. Like a ripple across still water, the message passed from bird to bird, echoing further and further, ultimately well beyond the final judge position 20 kilometers away.

The judges deliberated. The lion had made the loudest sound, but it was the dove's call that traveled the farthest - not by strength, but by continuity.

Rabbi Hool would say that this is the essence of Seder night. The victory does not belong to the one who makes the loudest noise, but to the ones whose message endures and travels furthest. Not the lion, not the elephant, not the monkey, but the dove, whose quiet consistency carries truth across generations.

That is what כלל ישראל does each year on the night of the סדר. We sit with our families and we tell the story. This year it is 3,337 years since יציאת מצרים, and we're still telling the same story. While mighty empires have risen and fallen - Babylonians, Persians, Greeks, Romans - leaving only echoes in history books, the Jewish people continue to transmit our legacy. We are not the loudest, but we are the most enduring. Through every גלות, through every challenge, the voice of our ancestors continues to be heard because we take the time, year after year, to ensure it is carried forward.

And so, may we all take heart on the Seder night, remembering that our strength lies not in spectacle, but in sacred transmission - in telling the story again, and again, and again. Until משיח comes, may our voices continue to carry across generations.”

